fieldwork

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Discovery call guide

Fieldwork · Practise AI on real work.

Discovery call guide

Version 0.1, 14 October 2026. For a 30-minute first call with an owner, director or operations manager at an estate agency, letting agency or property company (UK or Nigeria). Goal of the call: decide together whether a small pilot is worth scoping. Not to sell training in 30 minutes.

Your stance. You are new and you say so. You are curious, you take notes, you do not pitch before you understand. You are allowed to say "that is not a fit for us yet".

1. Before the call (10 minutes)

- Look at their website and two live listings. Note listing style, any visible inconsistency, branches, portals used. Do not criticise their listings on the call.
- Check whether they have taken the assessment (look for the summary the prospect pasted or emailed). If yes, read it: level (foundation, emerging, ready), priority workflows, constraints, team size.
- Confirm the country. Have the right data-protection reference ready: UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 (UK); Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023 (Nigeria). You are not giving legal advice.
- Open the notes template (section 9). Have the demo link ready in case they ask.

2. Agenda (30 minutes)

MIN	SEGMENT	PURPOSE
0 to 3	Open and frame	Agree the purpose and the time. Be honest that Fieldwork is new.
3 to 8	Their business	Size, branches, tools, who does what.
8 to 18	Workflows and pain	Where time goes, where quality varies, how staff use AI now.
18 to 22	Rules, data, constraints	Written rules, data worries, connectivity, cost of tools.
22 to 26	What a pilot could look like	Describe the 4-week outline in plain words. Check reaction.
26 to 30	Decide next step	Close (section 7). Book it before hanging up.

Opening script. "Thanks for making the time. I will use the 30 minutes to understand how your team works today. I will ask a lot of questions, then say whether I think a small pilot makes sense, and you can say the same. One thing upfront: Fieldwork is new. I have no case studies to show you, and I will not make any up. What I can do is show you how the training works on a fictional example and run a small, easy-to-stop pilot with you. Is it all right if I take notes?"

3. The 30 questions

Ask in order within groups. You will not ask all 30. Pick what the conversation needs, but cover every group.

A. Business and people (5)

1. How many people work in the business, and across how many branches or offices?
2. Roughly how many are in sales, lettings, property management, admin and marketing?
3. Who would you want in a small first group? Who is the most sceptical person you would also want in it?
4. How has staff turnover been over the last year, and how many people joined recently?
5. Which systems do people work in all day (CRM, portal uploads, email, spreadsheets, WhatsApp)?

B. Current AI use (5)

6. Do you know whether staff use AI tools for work today? Which ones, and for what?
7. Has anyone had a bad experience, such as a wrong fact, an embarrassing message, or a worry about data?
8. Does the business pay for any AI tool? Who decided, and on what basis?
9. How do staff pay for or access tools? (Nigeria: how do they handle dollar-priced subscriptions and data costs?)
10. What would you like staff to be doing with AI in a year that they are not doing now?

C. Workflows and pain (7)

11. Where do your people spend the most repeated writing or admin time?
12. Walk me through how a listing goes from instruction to live. Who writes it, who checks it, who approves it?
13. How consistent are listings across negotiators? How would you know?
14. How are routine enquiries and viewing requests answered? How fast, and by whom?
15. How do you report viewing feedback to vendors or landlords? What happens when feedback is negative?
16. What internal reports or weekly notes take someone an hour or more to write?
17. Which procedures are written down, and does anyone actually read them?

D. Onboarding and knowledge (3)

18. How long does a new starter take to work independently? How do you know?
19. What do new starters ask that is always the same?
20. If your best negotiator left tomorrow, what would be lost that is not written down?

(Do not sell the onboarding platform. It is planned, not built, not for sale. If they are interested, note it as "platform interest" and offer the waitlist.)

E. Rules, data and risk (5)

21. Do you have a written rule about what staff may put into AI tools? Do staff know it?
22. What worries you most: client data, wrong facts in listings, tone, regulators, something else?
23. Who is responsible for data protection in the business? Do you work with an outside adviser?
24. How do you handle consumer-protection and listing-accuracy obligations today? (Listen. Do not advise. Describe their answer back to them.)
25. Are there things you have said staff must never use AI for?

F. Decision, budget and timing (5)

26. Who else needs to be involved before you would try something like this?
27. Have you bought training for staff before? What worked, what did not?
28. Is there a budget line for training or for improving operations? Roughly what range feels reasonable for a four-week pilot? (Do not quote yet. Listen.)
29. What would make you say, after four weeks, that the pilot was worth doing? What would you want to measure?
30. If this looked right, when would you realistically want to start? What else is competing for your attention?

4. What to say about price on a first call

"We scope and price after a conversation, because the right size depends on your team and workflows. Typically a pilot is a fixed fee that you can approve in one go. I will send a one-page proposal within two working days with a number in it, and you can tell me if it is way off." Never quote a number on the call unless the scorecard is 14+ and you have the pricing hypothesis from SALES-PRICING-ASSUMPTIONS.md to hand. Always label it a proposal to be confirmed in writing.

5. Red flags

RED FLAG	WHAT IT MAY MEAN	WHAT TO DO
"We want you to tell us which properties to price / which tenants to accept."	They want AI to make decisions you refuse to support.	Restate "AI drafts, people decide". Decline that scope. If they persist, disqualify.
"Can you guarantee we will save X hours or avoid regulators?"	Looking for guarantees.	"No. I can help you measure." If they need a guarantee, disqualify.
No named owner, "just send it to the team".	No internal sponsor, adoption will fail.	Make a named owner a condition of a pilot.
Wants to paste real client data into tools to "get started".	Data protection exposure.	Pause. Insist on anonymised examples.
Wants a free pilot with weekly staff time for 12 people and no commitment.	Low commitment.	Require named time and a decision date. Discount in return for feedback, not for free work.
Only the owner is interested; the team is hostile or unaware.	Change-management risk.	Suggest a smaller first group and an honest briefing to staff.
Wants the platform or a custom tool built.	Scope mismatch.	"That is planned, not built, not for sale." Offer training only.
Wants a very large rollout straight away.	Over-scoped for a new company.	Propose a pilot group of six to ten first.
Legal or regulatory advice requested.	Outside scope.	Refer to their professional body or solicitor.
Expects you to know their local regulation in detail.	Overclaiming risk.	State what you do and do not know; mark anything you cannot verify.

6. Qualification scorecard

Score each 0, 1 or 2 straight after the call. Total out of 20.

#	CRITERION	0	1	2
1	Pain is real and specific	Vague	Some	Specific workflow and a recent example
2	Named sponsor with authority	None	Influencer	Owner or director on the call
3	Named day-to-day owner	None	Possible	Named and time found
4	Team size 5 to 25 for a first pilot	Under 3 or over 40	Edges	5 to 25
5	Willing to use anonymised examples	No	Reluctant	Yes
6	Accepts "AI drafts, people decide"	No	Mixed	Yes, welcomes it
7	Budget conversation possible	Refuses	Vague	Gave a range or a process
8	Timing within 8 weeks	None	Vague	Specific start window
9	Willing to measure against a baseline	No	Maybe	Yes
10	Realistic expectations (no guarantees)	Unrealistic	Mixed	Realistic

14 to 20: Send a proposal within 2 working days. 9 to 13: Nurture; run the assessment together or offer a practice session. 0 to 8: Polite no or stay in touch; do not spend further time.

Record the assessment self-reported level alongside: foundation, emerging or ready. It informs the pilot design, not the qualification.

7. How to close

Close on a specific next step, never "let me know". Options:

- **Proposal path (14+):** "Based on what you told me, I would suggest a four-week pilot on [workflow] with [number] people. I will send a one-page proposal by [date]. Can we pencil in a 20-minute call on [date] to go through it?"
- **Demo path (9 to 13):** "Would it help to see the training on a fictional example? It takes 20 minutes. Who else should be there?" Book it now.
- **Assessment path:** "Take the free assessment with [owner] and send me the summary. We will use it on our next call."
- **Parking:** "It sounds like the timing is not right. May I check back in [month]? In the meantime I will send you our free exercise."

Always: confirm who does what by when, and send a follow-up within 24 hours (see FOLLOW-UP-TEMPLATES.md).

Trial close. "If a pilot came back at a price you were comfortable with and you could see what it would measure, what else would stop you saying yes?" Write the answer down word for word.

8. After the call (10 minutes)

Within an hour: complete the notes template, score, update the CRM (CRM-FIELDS-AND-PIPELINE.md), set the next action date, send the follow-up email.

9. Notes template

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 DISCOVERY CALL NOTES
Date / time / duration:
Account:                        Country: UK / Nigeria / Other
Attendees (name, role):
Source of lead:                 Assessment taken? Y/N  Level: foundation / emerging / ready

BUSINESS: staff #, branches, systems
CURRENT AI USE: who, which tools, any incidents
RULES / DATA: written rule? data owner? outside adviser?
TOP 3 WORKFLOWS (their words):
1.
2.
3.
ONBOARDING: time to independence, repeated questions
DECISION: sponsor, day-to-day owner, other stakeholders, process
BUDGET SIGNAL (their words, not ours):
TIMING / TRIGGER:
SUCCESS MEASURE THEY NAMED:
OBJECTIONS RAISED (verbatim):
RED FLAGS:
SCORECARD: 1_ 2_ 3_ 4_ 5_ 6_ 7_ 8_ 9_ 10_  TOTAL __/20
NEXT STEP (what, who, date):
FOLLOW-UP SENT: Y/N (date)
THINGS I PROMISED:
THINGS I DID NOT KNOW AND MUST CHECK:
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10. Rules of conduct on the call

- Never state a number as fact unless it is in their data. Never quote a statistic about AI productivity.
- If asked about regulation: "It differs by country and changes. I teach your team to follow your rules; I am not a lawyer. Your professional body or solicitor is the right place."
- If asked for references: "I do not have any yet. I can show you a fictional worked example, and I would rather you decide on that than on a testimonial I cannot give."
- Do not criticise other trainers, tools or their current staff.